

Polling Plan: Utah AI Data Centers

Universe. Utah registered voters. Registered voters are the most relevant population because AI data center development is likely to become a local and statewide political issue involving zoning, utilities, taxation, and infrastructure planning. However, if the client's primary concern is community impact rather than electoral or legislative risk, I would consider expanding the universe to all Utah adults (18+ population) or residents living in directly affected communities, since the economic and environmental effects of AI data centers may extend beyond the registered voter population.

Sample design. Voter-file-based text-to-web survey supplemented with email-to-web where available. Stratify by region, age, gender, party registration, race/ethnicity, education, and urbanicity. I would recommend modest over-samples in areas most likely to experience direct effects from AI data center development, including Utah County, Eagle Mountain, West Jordan, and fast-growing suburban communities.

Target n / MOE. Target statewide n=800 completed interviews, producing an expected margin of sampling error of approximately ± 3.5 percentage points at the 95% confidence level before design effects. This estimate uses the standard polling approximation for a proportion under the conservative maximum-variance assumption ($p=0.50$). Sources: [\[Pew Research Survey Methodology\]](#), [Penn State - Computing Necessary Sample Size](#)

Mode. Primary mode should be text-to-web because it is fast, cost-efficient, and compatible with voter-file recruitment. Email-to-web can supplement responses among older or higher-propensity voters.

Quotas. Soft quotas on age, gender, race/ethnicity, education, region, party registration, and urbanicity. Regional balancing is especially important because opinions may vary substantially between rural Utah, suburban growth corridors, and communities near proposed data center projects.

Weighting. Samples should be weighted to correct for unequal selection probability and nonresponse. They should also be weighted to match Utah registered voter demographics for age, gender, race/ethnicity, education, region, urbanicity, and party registration using voter-file benchmarks and the most recent Census/ACS estimates for the 18+ population. If multiple recruitment modes are used (e.g. cell phone-only, landline-only, both), weights should additionally account for coverage differences and overlaps across recruitment methods. Party registration targets should be based on current Utah voter-file statistics or averages from recent high-quality statewide polling. All reported margins of sampling error should acknowledge potential design effects introduced through weighting.

Crosstab plan. Core cuts should include party registration, ideology, age, homeownership/rent status, education, region, and proximity to proposed data center sites. Key analytical dimensions include support for AI data centers, water-use concerns, electricity-cost concerns, local-control attitudes, and jobs-versus-environment tradeoffs.

Methodological risks.

1. **Low awareness:** Many voters may know little about AI data centers, making results sensitive to wording and framing. I would measure unaided awareness before aided awareness and keep question wording neutral.
2. **Local exposure bias:** Residents near proposed sites may hold very different opinions from the statewide electorate. I would over-sample affected communities and analyze them separately.
3. **Coverage/nonresponse bias:** Text-to-web surveys may underrepresent less digitally engaged voters. I would mitigate this through quotas, weighting, and supplemental email recruitment.

Expansion to Texas. For Texas, I would retain the same core questionnaire for comparability but increase the sample to roughly n=1,000–1,200 due to Texas's larger geography and demographic diversity. The Texas version should include stronger regional stratification and additional questions on grid reliability, electricity demand, and local infrastructure impacts.